

Americas

1. North American white sturgeon

Similar to sturgeons living 100 million years ago, this fish depends heavily on its sense of smell.



2. American paddlefish

Takes its name from its long, paddle-shaped snout.



3. Alligator gar

Hides in aquatic plants to ambush its prey.



4. Electric eel

Generates huge electric shocks to stun prey and ward off attackers.



5. Redtail catfish

Stops feeding to shed its skin like a snake.



6. Spectacled caiman

Named after the bony ridge between its eyes.



7. Arapaima

The adult fish relies on air-breathing, not gills, to get oxygen. But its need to come to the surface makes it vulnerable to hunters.



8. Amazon river dolphin

Hunts in the murky water by sonar and uses its long snout to catch prey hiding in underwater plants. Females are normally larger than males.

Eurasia



9. Wels catfish

Uses its fins to capture prey before swallowing its catch whole.



10. Beluga sturgeon

The world's largest river fish, it spends some of its life in salt water. Extra-large beluga no longer exist due to persistent overfishing and poaching of the species.

A LARGE CROCODILE CAN GO FOR MORE THAN 1 YEAR BETWEEN MEALS

North American white sturgeon
20 ft (6.1 m)
Columbia River

1

American paddlefish
7 ft (2.2 m)
Mississippi River

2

Electric eel
6.7 ft (2 m)
Orinoco River

4

Alligator gar
8–10 ft (2.4–3 m)
Mississippi River

3

Redtail catfish
4.3 ft (1.3 m)
Essequibo River

5

Spectacled caiman
8.2 ft (2.5 m)
Essequibo River

6

Arapaima
8.2 ft (2.5 m)
Amazon River

7

Amazon river dolphin
8.2 ft (2.5 m)
Amazon River

8

Marbled lungfish
6.6 ft (2 m)
River Nile

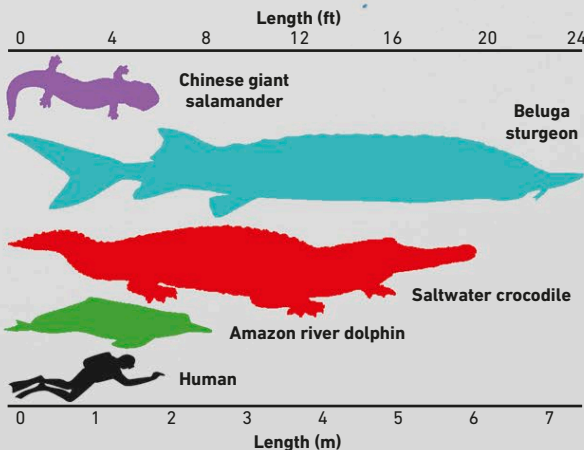
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Goliath tigerfish
4.9 ft (1.5 m)
Congo River

12

Becoming giant

The sizes of river monsters shown here are mainly extreme historical records. It has always been rare for them to reach such sizes, but is especially so these days, since most are overfished and several are critically endangered.



Australasia

22. Saltwater crocodile

The largest reptile in the world, it can kill and eat prey as large as horses and will not hesitate to kill humans who invade its territory.



23. Freshwater crocodile

Much smaller than its saltwater relative, it will not attack humans unless provoked.